

INDIA PICTURE

Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan

(1902-1968)

A maestro difficult to box into categories—even his Patiala Gharana. From the intricate filigree work he wove so casually into his singing, whether a sombre Marwa or a nakhra-filled thumri, to the sapat taans that flowed like a river in spate, to the three-octave voice that seemed able to swell to a baritone or slenderise to a soprano at will, he was an elemental force. His *Prem Jogan Ban* in Sohini for *Mughal-E-Azam* poses a sonorous what-if to film music; his *Hari Om Tatsat* is a touchstone for bhajan.

Begum Akhtar

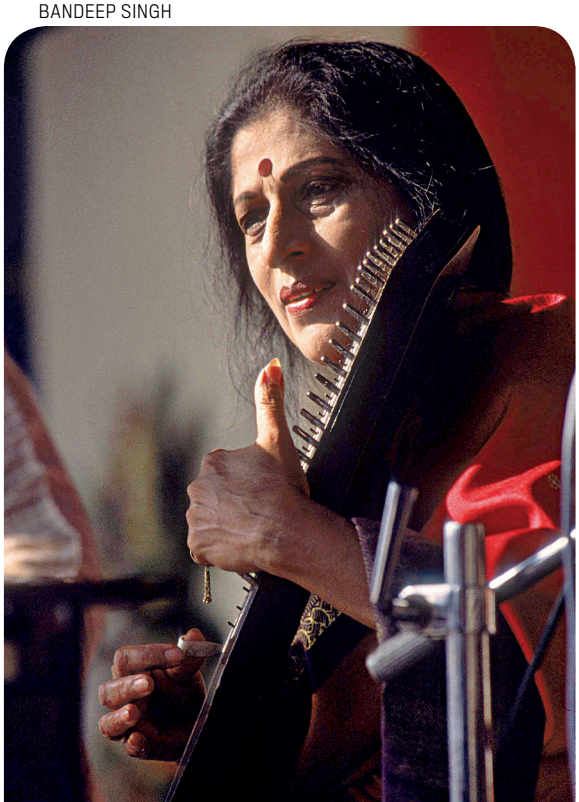
(1914-1974)

The diva with a base layer of melancholy in her renditions is iconic both in the world of ghazal and thumri. Born at a time when the old aesthetic universe of the tawaifs was being challenged by colonial-era prudery, she reclaimed a new cachet for tradition with the sheer expressiveness of her singing and clarity of enunciation, deriving soul and feel from her life, as it were.



BCCL

BANDEEP SINGH



Kishori Amonkar

(1932-2017)

Daughter of the Jaipur Gharana doyenne Mogubai Kurdikar, Kishoriji led her life and music on her own terms. A perfectionist, she would only step onto stage to sing once her tanpuras were totally in tune. This at times would delay her concerts, but die-hard fans never minded the wait, because what ensued would be the purest statements of a hallowed inner being. Her spiritual and musical quest, both being inextricable, was woven out of a certain self-defined purity. Her *Biraha Bamana* in Bhimpalasi could give pause to a storm, and her rendition of Bhupali—*Sahela Re*—not only defines who she was but also the beauty that is Hindustani music.